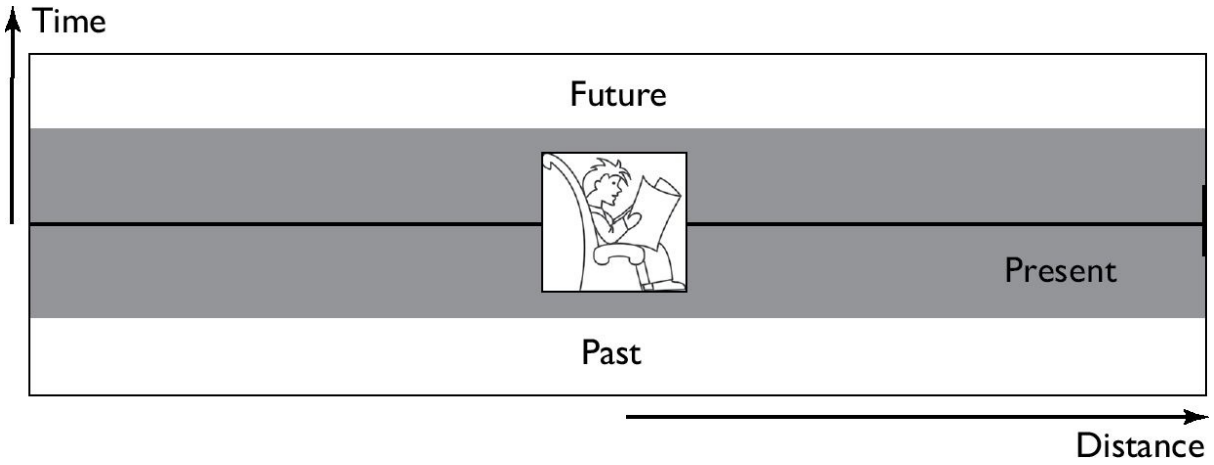


Figure 3.1 Space and time before Einstein.

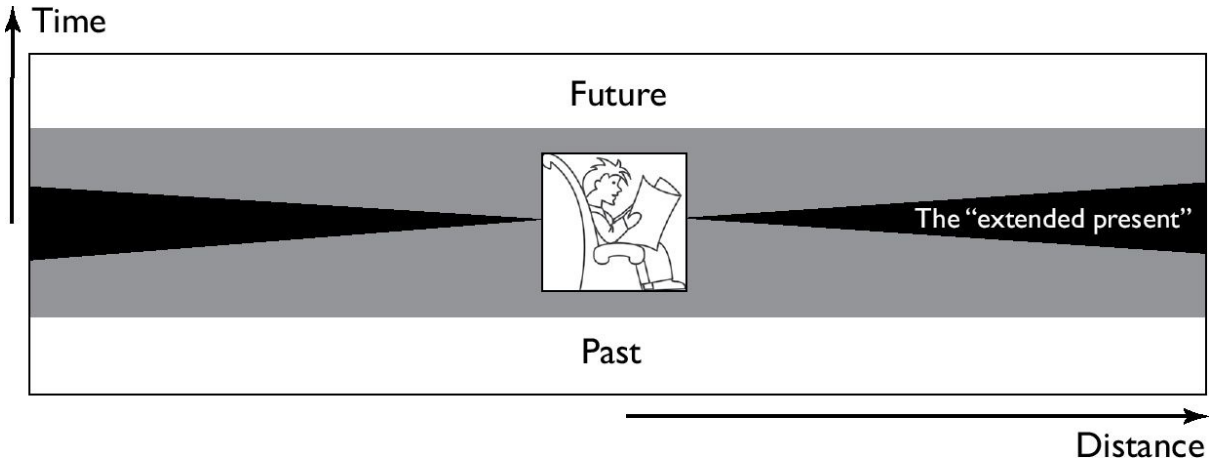


Figure 3.2 The structure of 'spacetime'. For every observer, the 'extended present' is the intermediate zone between the past and the future.

The duration of this intermediate zone,[fn10] which is neither in your past nor in your future, is very small and depends on where an event takes place relative to you, as illustrated in figure 3.2: the greater the distance of the event from you, the longer the duration of the extended present. At a distance of a few metres from your nose, dear reader, the duration of what for you is the intermediate zone, neither past nor future, is no more than a few nanoseconds: next to nothing (the number of nanoseconds in a second is the same as the number of seconds in thirty years). This is much less than we could possibly notice. On the other side of the ocean, the duration of this intermediate zone is a thousandth of a second, still well below the threshold of our perception of time – the minimum amount of time we perceive with our senses – which is somewhere in the order of a tenth of a second. But on the Moon the duration of the expanded present is a few seconds, and on Mars it is a quarter of an hour. This means we can say that, on Mars, there are events that in this precise moment have already happened, events that are yet to happen, but also